SARI STATECRAFT



As important as the economic signals the Union budget sends is the sartorial statement Union finance minister **Nirmala Sitharaman** makes while presenting it. It was a handwoven Kanjivaram silk sari this time, a purple kattam with light golden-brown checks and a coffee-brown border, a tribute to Tamil Nadu's storied weaving tradition. Like the diplomatic gesture European Commission president Ursula von der Leyen's made with her Benarasi brocade jacket during her Republic Day appearance, the FM's sartorial choices too are an exercise in soft advocacy, whether the drape is Kanjivaram, Mangalgiri, Ikat, Kantha or Madhubani.

JAB THEY MET



It did not matter that their meeting produced no alliance, seat deal or ideological exchange. The very fact that CPI(M) state secretary **Mohammad Salim** met former Trinamool Congress leader **Humayun Kabir** at a New Town hotel was enough to stir outrage. Kabir, suspended from TMC and now running the Janata Unnayan Party, has a reputation for communal overtures. No amount of clarifications from Salim that in politics everybody speaks to everybody could undo the damage.

IF WORDS CAN KILL



Like her husband, the cricketer Ravindra Jadeja, **Rivaba Jadeja** can bowl a political googly as well as she can pick one. Responding to Rahul Gandhi's social media attack on crime in Gujarat, the BJP minister said the state is far safer than he claims, especially for women, citing crime rates well below the national average. She didn't stop at that, though, predicting that the Congress would be reduced to 'single digits' next state election from its 17-seat tally in 2022 (currently down to 12 after five defections). The words are decimating enough, but who will have the last stab?

Kaushik Deka with Anilesh S. Mahajan, Sonal Khetarpal, Amitabh Srivastava, Arkamoy Datta Majumdar and Jumana Shah

HEALTH WATCH

By **Sonali Acharjee**

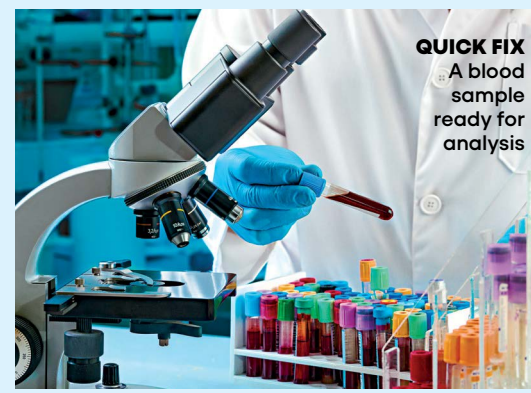
NEW SINGLE TEST FOR MULTIPLE INFECTIONS

Just one sample to detect multiple illnesses, from dengue, flu, COVID-19 to typhoid, all of which exhibit several symptoms? That could well become possible if a new diagnostic test being developed by the Indian Council of Medical Research (ICMR) is introduced widely. It could help doctors quickly diagnose the exact ailment a patient may be suffering from and begin the appropriate treatment sooner.

Currently, many patients have to go through multiple tests, which can be time-consuming, expensive and sometimes lead to unnecessary or incorrect treatments. By combining these checks into a single tool, the ICMR hopes to speed up diagnosis and expedite the care patients need.

This also comes at a critical time for India, where antimicrobial resistance is rising. According to studies, up to 83 per cent of patients may carry bacteria that are resistant to antibiotics. A test like this could help doctors avoid prescribing antibiotics when they are not actually needed, which is essential to slow down this dangerous and alarming trend.

Once ready, the test could become especially valuable during outbreaks and health emergencies, helping India respond more effectively and in the process protect more lives.



QUICK FIX A blood sample ready for analysis